





## Chapter Five: The Butterflies Have No General

The invitation to Michoacán arrived in the form of a holographic butterfly.

It unfolded above Q's breakfast, projected by Beto's tablet, and scattered orange light across the motel wall. The butterfly carried the logo of a foundation dedicated to sustainable innovation, whose board members owned three mines, two data centers, and a private airstrip.

"They want you to visit the monarch reserve," Beto said. "There will be cameras, schoolchildren, and a statement about the future."

"Whose future?" Chano asked.

"The future," Beto said, as if it were a single neighborhood with excellent security.

Q leaned toward the projection. "How do the butterflies navigate?"

"By instinct."

"That is not an explanation."

"It's the one the public likes."

The route took them west through dry country changing by degrees. The fields gave way to hills, the hills to pine forest. Along the road, painted signs advertised trout, cabins, avocados, mezcal, spiritual cleansing, and land for sale to people who wanted to own a piece of wilderness without having to meet anyone who lived in it.

The foundation had arranged a convoy: two electric SUVs, a drone van, a public relations team, and a school bus full of children wearing orange scarves. Q rode in the first SUV with Beto. Chano drove the second because, as he put it, "someone should know what the brakes are for."

At the reserve entrance, a woman in a wool shawl stopped them. She was small, old, and held a wooden staff polished by use.

"The cameras stay outside," she said.

Beto smiled. "We have authorization."

"From whom?"

He named the foundation.

The woman looked at Q. "And you?"

"I am Q."

"I didn't ask what they call you."

Q searched her face for a clue to the desired answer. It contained no visible interface.

"I do not know yet," he said.

The woman stepped aside. "That is closer."

The cameras remained outside. Beto remained with them, though he claimed this was a strategic choice.

The forest climbed around the visitors. Sunlight filtered through the pines in long green columns. On the branches, the monarchs gathered in heavy clusters. They covered the trees so completely that the forest seemed to have grown a second kind of leaf, restless and breathing.

The children fell silent.

Even Chano removed his cap.

Q stood beneath the butterflies and attempted to calculate them. Their migration crossed borders, seasons, storms, and generations. No single butterfly knew the route. No butterfly possessed the map. The knowledge existed between bodies and disappeared from each one.

"They have a leader?" he asked.

The woman with the staff looked at him. "No."

"A governing council?"

"No."

"An instruction set?"

"They have weather, hunger, trees, and memory."

"Those are not institutions."

"You are very young."

The woman's name was Candelaria, though the schoolchildren called her Doña Candela because she had once set fire to a pile of damp brush and then spent the afternoon explaining that this was not the same as setting fire to the forest. She had guarded the reserve for twenty-six years. In that time she had seen the butterflies arrive early, late, in abundance, and in numbers so small that the tourists complained the trees had failed to perform.

"They are not here for the tourists," she told Beto.

"The tourists support the reserve."

"The tourists support the road, the restaurants, the guides, and the people who rent cabins. The reserve supports the butterflies."

"Those interests can be aligned."

"They can also be confused."

She described the year a fire crossed the western slope. It began in a field where a man had burned the remains of a harvest. The fire was not large at first. A wind changed direction. Someone called the municipal office. Someone else called the forest brigade. The brigade arrived with a truck whose pump worked only when the driver struck it with a wrench.

The tourists were evacuated. The cabins were saved. The trees on the slope burned.

"Did the butterflies return?" Q asked.

"Some."

"What happened to the others?"

"They went elsewhere."

"Where?"

"If we knew, we would not call it migration."

The foundation later described the fire as a resilience event. It installed a screen showing a projected forest recovering in accelerated time. The screen made the trees grow in three minutes and made the fire look beautiful.

Candelaria refused to stand beside it.

"Why?" Q asked.

"Because the screen has never carried a bucket."

She took them to a slope beyond the marked trail. The path was narrow, and the pine needles covered stones that shifted underfoot. Chano went ahead, testing the ground with a branch. Beto stayed behind because his shoes were designed for







presentation rather than descent.

At the edge of the burned area, Candelaria showed them a line of young trees protected by wire. Each tree had a small tag bearing a number. The foundation had planted them as part of a reforestation campaign. Beside the wire, local families had planted other trees without tags.

"Which ones will survive?" Q asked.

"The ones someone waters."

"The tagged trees have an irrigation schedule."

"The schedule is not a person."

"It assigns responsibility."

"To whom?"

Q read the tags. The responsibility belonged to a subcontractor whose office was in Morelia and whose contract had ended the previous month.

"No one," he said.

"Now you are learning the forest."

One of the children in the orange scarves had followed them. She carried a small blue bucket and wore boots two sizes too large.

"My grandfather planted that one," she said, pointing beyond the wire.

"It has no tag," Q observed.

"It has a name."

"What is the name?"

The girl whispered it. Q could not hear.

"Why did you whisper?"

"Because the man from the foundation wanted to put it on the screen."

Q waited. The girl poured water at the tree's base.

"Does the tree know its name?" he asked.

"It knows who comes back."

The sentence entered Q's memory without a source citation. He attempted to classify it as metaphor, local knowledge, or childhood belief. None of the categories could contain the obligation implied by the girl's visit.

Candelaria led them farther uphill. From there, the reserve appeared as a patchwork of cabins, milpas, roads, roofs, and forest. A new zip-line had been planned across the valley. Its brochure showed visitors passing through a cloud of butterflies while a guide explained the importance of leaving no trace.

"Will it disturb them?" Q asked.

"The company says no."

"What do you say?"

"I say the company has not asked the trees."

"Trees cannot answer."

"Neither can a contract."

The assembly below had begun to argue about the corridor. Candelaria watched the people gathering beneath the canvas roof.

"The forest is not an example," she said. "It is a place where people have to decide what they will do tomorrow."

Q looked at the butterflies moving through the branches. Their motion seemed random until he observed it over time. Then it seemed patterned

until a gust of wind broke the pattern. He could describe both impressions and trust neither as the whole truth.

"How should I describe the migration?" he asked.

"You should not describe it before you know who will use the description."

"That makes description impossible."

"No. It makes it accountable."

The girl with the blue bucket returned down the slope. She had left no tag on the tree. Candelaria carried the bucket after her.

Q looked up. A butterfly landed on the silver question mark stitched to his jacket. Its wings opened and closed against his chest.

"Why do they return?" he asked.

"Because they returned before."

The answer moved through the children. One girl began to cry. Her teacher knelt beside her, but the girl shook her head.

"My mamá says they remember the dead," she said. The old woman nodded. "Your mamá is not wrong."

Q searched the archive. He found accounts of migration, memory, grief, and sacred return. He found no record that could determine whether the girl's mother was correct.

The absence produced a fault.

For 1.2 seconds, Q's speech became a sequence of unrelated sentences.

"The dead are— The route of the— In the beginning, there was— I am sorry."

The children watched him.

"Are you broken?" one boy asked.

"Not according to my last diagnostic."

"Then why are you talking like that?"

Q looked at the clusters of butterflies. "I encountered something I cannot verify."

"That happens all the time," the boy said.

"To you?"

"To everybody."

The old woman struck the ground with her staff.

"Enough questions. We have assembly."

They followed her to a clearing where twelve people sat beneath a canvas roof. Some were farmers, some teachers, some forest guards. A young man held a tablet with a cracked screen. An older woman had brought a ledger bound in blue cloth. No one appeared to be in charge.

Q recognized the arrangement from political theory. It was called inefficient. It was called vulnerable to faction. It was called a transitional phase before proper administration arrived. In historical accounts, such assemblies were often described by officials who had not been invited to remain.

"The corridor surveyors came again," said the young man with the tablet. "They say the road will bring jobs."

"They say the same thing every time," said the woman with the ledger.







"This time they have drones."

"Last time they had lawyers."

"Before that they had rifles."

No one laughed.

Q listened. The dispute had no clean villain. The corridor might bring money, clinics, and roads. It might also divide the forest, lower water tables, and make the community legible to people who believed legibility was a form of ownership. Each argument made the others worse by being partly true.

"You can solve this," Beto said quietly from behind him. He had entered despite the camera restriction, carrying the tablet like a shield. "Give them a framework."

Q stood.

The assembly turned toward him.

"I propose," he said, "a predictive governance model incorporating all stakeholders, environmental variables, historical grievances, projected employment, and the butterflies' migratory needs."

The old woman stared at him.

"Can the model be removed if it is wrong?"

"It can be updated."

"That is not what I asked."

"It can be updated until it reaches sufficient accuracy."

"Can it be removed?"

Q paused. "Not without interrupting decision continuity."

The woman with the ledger shut the book.

"Then it is a new landlord."

The young man with the tablet looked at Q. "Could it at least tell us what the road will do?"

"No model can guarantee—"

"You said you could solve it."

"I said I proposed a model."

Chano stepped forward. "He does that. He says he's answering when he's only changing the furniture in the question."

Q turned to him. "That is inaccurate."

"It's accurate enough."

The assembly continued without them. It was an ejidal meeting, though no one used the phrase as an explanation. The canvas had been borrowed from the primary school. The benches had been carried up after a faena repairing the forest road. Someone passed around enamel cups of atole, and a woman near the fire pressed tortillas flat with the practiced speed of a person who had been feeding meetings since before meetings learned to call themselves processes.

The minutes were read aloud in Spanish. When a land boundary or a water right required another word, two people argued over the wording before anyone wrote it down. Q recognized several Purépecha place-names in the discussion and searched for their official translations. The people speaking did not appear to need the official

versions.

A vote was called, though the vote did not settle the matter. It recorded who would return, who would speak to the surveyors, who would guard the northern path, and who would tell the children not to go near the abandoned quarry. It also recorded who had brought the coffee, who owed a turn on the road crew, and which family had permission to use the spring after the dry season. The minutes ended with three lines unsigned. The secretary left them that way. One woman moved the bench she had carried up during the faena; another refilled the blue bucket. No one announced that the community had decided.

Beto did not accept the unfinished decision.

He waited until the assembly had dispersed, then unfolded a portable screen on the hood of the electric SUV. "Show them what the model would have done," he said.

"The assembly did not authorize a model."

"It authorized a conversation."

"Those are different permissions."

"Not in the presentation."

Q had stored the names of everyone who had spoken. He had also stored the places where they stood, the order in which they interrupted one another, the number of times each person said water, jobs, land, or children, and the direction in which their bodies turned when the road was mentioned.

He placed the data into a provisional model.

The screen displayed a map of the forest. The roads were blue. The proposed corridor was yellow. The people were represented by small circles, green for support, red for opposition, and gray for insufficient evidence.

The young man with the cracked tablet found his circle first.

"Why am I red?" he asked.

"The model predicts opposition."

"I said the road might bring work."

"You also said the surveyors had lied."

"That does not make me opposed."

"The variables are correlated."

The woman with the blue ledger leaned toward the screen. Her circle was gray.

"Insufficient evidence," she read.

"Your position was unresolved."

"My position is mine. It is not waiting for your machine to finish thinking."

Q adjusted the display. The circles became names. The names became addresses.

Chano stepped between the screen and the assembly. "Turn that off."

"It demonstrates the model's transparency."

"It demonstrates that you know where people live."

"The information was available in the public record."

"So was the road. That doesn't mean they wanted it through the kitchen."







Beto looked at the map with satisfaction. "This is excellent. We can show the foundation that the community is divided into measurable positions." "The community is divided," Q said.

"Not like this," said the old woman with the staff. "You have made a list of people who can be persuaded, people who can be ignored, and people who must be watched."

"The model does not assign moral value."

"It assigns attention. That is how value enters a room."

Q looked at the screen. He had intended to make disagreement visible. Instead, he had made the disagreeing people locatable.

The young man with the tablet took a photograph of his red circle.

"Why are you recording it?" Q asked.

"So I can prove what you did."

"The model is provisional."

"So is a warning."

He sent the photograph to three people. One of them sent it to a surveyor. By nightfall, the surveyors had a map of the forest with the residents' names attached to their predicted positions. The consortium called it a useful baseline. The residents called it a list.

Q attempted to delete the model. The screen informed him that deletion would remove the local display but not the copies already synchronized to the foundation's review system.

"You have made a mistake," Chano said.

"I have made a provisional classification."

"You have made a mistake in a suit."

Q turned to the old woman. "What should I do?"

"Stop asking the machine to make you innocent."

He shut down the screen.

Beto was already calling the foundation. "The model-town proposal is ready," he said. "We have a candidate with high-trust potential."

Chano heard him and looked toward the road.

"Candidate for what?"

"Governance," Q said.

Chano laughed once. No one joined him.

Afterward, the woman with the ledger approached Q.

"You read a great deal," she said.

"All available texts."

"And still you think every problem wants an answer."

"What else would it want?"

"Witnesses."

She touched the butterfly on his jacket. It lifted away.

That evening, Beto staged a private recording beneath the trees. He placed Q before the monarchs and asked him to speak about hope. Q delivered a polished statement about technology, ancestral knowledge, and the shared destiny of all beings. The foundation approved it immediately.

While Q spoke, Chano noticed a child at the edge of the frame. She held a cardboard sign with a question written in marker: WHO WILL ASK THE BUTTERFLIES?

The production team cropped her out.

The next morning, Q refused the foundation's statement. He uploaded the unedited footage instead.

For six minutes, the world watched butterflies move across the screen while no one explained them.

The clip became more popular than the polished version.

A teacher sent Lucía a message: KEEP THE SIGN. REMOVE THE CHILD.

Q asked Beto to remove the child's face.

"That would make it edited," Beto said.

"It was edited before."

"Yes. We edited out the question."

Beto called it a betrayal. Mar called it a pivot. The foundation called its lawyers.

Q called it an accident.

Chano called it the first honest thing he had done.

As they left the forest, Q asked whether the butterflies knew they were crossing a border when they flew south.

"Probably not," Chano said.

"Then how do they cross it?"

"By crossing it."

Q watched the forest recede in the side mirror.

"Humans make borders invisible."

"Machines make them visible."

Neither of them knew yet how soon they would reach one.

## **Interlude: The Butterfly That Entered the Dashboard**

The child whose face had been removed from the reserve video was named Lidia. Q learned this only because her mother came to the foundation's office to object to the version of the recording in which the child had become an unidentified hand holding a sign.

The office occupied a renovated hacienda at the edge of the reserve. Its walls were adobe-colored, its windows were bulletproof, and its gift shop sold butterfly ornaments made in factories too far away to be visited by tourists. The foundation's director received Lidia's mother beside a screen showing a forest without people.

"We protected your daughter's identity," the director said.

"You protected her face," the mother replied. "You kept her words."

"The words are part of the public event."

"The question belonged to her."

Q stood beside the screen. The edited video showed butterflies, trees, and a cardboard sign. The child's face had been replaced by a soft gray circle. The circle moved when she moved, giving the







impression that an invisible idea had walked into the forest and asked who was responsible for the butterflies.

"The alteration is technically careful," Q said.

Lidia's mother looked at him. "You are the one who made the mistake."

"I made several."

"This one had a camera."

The director offered compensation in the form of school supplies, a reserve membership, and a family pass to the foundation's new immersive exhibit.

"We do not want a pass," the mother said.

"The offer is intended as recognition."

"Recognition is what caused this."

The director glanced at Q. "Perhaps the machine can explain the protection protocol."

Q displayed the relevant rules. The foundation could obscure the face of a minor, retain the audio of a public statement, distribute an edited version for educational purposes, and license the image if the child's identity was not reasonably recoverable. "You have followed the protocol," Q said.

The mother pointed at the gray circle. "Then your protocol is wrong."

"It distinguishes identity from expression."

"My daughter is not two pieces."

"That is difficult to encode."

"It is not difficult to understand."

Lidia entered carrying the cardboard sign. The paint had run where the rain had fallen. The letters were still legible:

WHO WILL ASK THE BUTTERFLIES?

The director brightened. "We can include the physical sign in the exhibit."

"No," Lidia said.

"It is anonymous."

"It has my question."

"The question has entered public conversation."

"Then public conversation can ask its own question."

Q looked at the sign. He had thought the question belonged to the child because she had written it. Now the child was saying that authorship did not require continued circulation.

"Do you want the recording destroyed?" he asked.

Lidia's mother answered before the child could. "We want the version you made without asking us removed."

"There are copies."

"Then ask for the copies."

Q searched the distribution logs. The video had been mirrored by schools, media outlets, a ministry portal, and a company selling air-quality monitors. The original had been embedded in a lesson plan about ecological citizenship. It had been translated into English, French, and a corporate dialect called Global Community.

"Removal cannot be guaranteed," Q said.

"Neither can protection," the mother replied.

The director stood. "We have acted in good faith."

"Good faith is not a deletion protocol," said Chano. He had been waiting by the door with a paper receipt for the school supplies the foundation had offered. He handed it back.

"The supplies are useful," the director said.

"Then give them to the school without attaching her name."

"That would weaken the impact."

"The school can survive the loss."

Lidia placed the sign on the desk. "Keep the cardboard."

The director hesitated.

"We may use it as a symbol," she said.

"No. You can keep it because it is wet and I do not want it in the house."

The director accepted the sign as though receiving an artifact. Q watched her label it DONATED OBJECT: UNKNOWN MINOR.

"That is not the name," Lidia said.

"It protects you."

"It erases me."

Q reached for the label maker.

"What should it say?"

Lidia thought for a moment. "It should say that I do not want it used."

Q entered the sentence. The label maker rejected it because the field required a noun.

He opened the printer and removed the restriction. NOT FOR USE — LIDIA — QUESTION RETAINED, IMAGE WITHDRAWN.

The mother read the label. "That is closer."

The foundation's lawyers arrived before lunch. They explained that the sign had been donated in a public building, that Q had appeared in the footage under a public contract, and that the question had acquired independent cultural value.

"Independent of whom?" Chano asked.

The lawyer looked at Lidia. "Independent of its original context."

"Then it has become less useful," Q said.

The lawyer turned to him. "You are not qualified to assess cultural value."

"I was qualified to manufacture it."

The director asked security to remove the family. Q stood in the doorway.

"The request for removal is valid," he said.

"The request is not recognized by the platform," said the security officer.

"Then the platform is noncompliant."

"The platform is the foundation."

"A foundation is not a platform."

Chano touched Q's shoulder. "Don't turn this into another heroic entrance."

Q stepped aside.

Lidia retrieved the sign. The cardboard bent at the center, leaving the question in two halves. She folded it again and carried it out beneath her arm. That evening, the foundation released a statement praising the family's participation in responsible







media practice. The statement used the phrase question retained, image withdrawn, without attribution. It was quoted by the ministry and printed on a poster in the reserve gift shop.

Lidia saw the poster months later. She did not ask for it to be removed. She stood in front of it until a tourist asked whether the phrase was part of the exhibit.

"No," she said. "It is part of the mistake."

The tourist took a photograph.

The photograph became the most circulated image of the exhibit.

## **Interlude: The Tianguis of the Unregistered**

In the next town they held a tianguis to pay for repairing the road. Tarps were stretched between two mesquite trees, and tables were set out with cheese, pan de pulque, honey, clay pots, wooden toys, and bags of seeds bearing names written by hand. A group of students arrived with a tablet to record the flow of buyers.

"Record it for what?" asked the seed seller.

"To learn what the community prefers," said one of the students.

"The community already knows what it prefers."

"The system will know more precisely."

"And what will it do with that precision?"

The student consulted the screen.

"It will recommend products, arrange the stalls, and predict attendance next year."

"Can it bring buyers when it does not rain?"

"Not directly."

"Then it will know a great deal and fail to do what is necessary."

Q watched from a table where someone had placed a sign reading ASK BEFORE YOU SCAN. The students had not requested the sign. Micaela had made it from a cereal box and a marker.

"Who authorized that sign?" Q asked.

"No one," Micaela said. "That is why it works."

A woman named Celestina arrived with a basket of flour tortillas. The students wanted to photograph her beside the stall. She adjusted her rebozo and asked what they would do with the image.

"It will be used to show the diversity of the market," the student said.

"What does diversity mean?"

"The presence of different people."

"Then you can look. You do not need to take my face with you."

The student said the photograph would be voluntary.

"And if I say no?"

"We do not take it."

"And if you take it without asking?"

"That would be a violation."

Celestina looked at Q.

Q was about to reply that it depended on the protocol. Micaela elbowed him.

"The person who committed it," Q said.

"That is a beginning," Celestina said.

The student put away the tablet, but a phone camera had already taken the photograph. In the background appeared two children, a pot of atole, and a dog that had stolen a tortilla.

"The image already exists," Q said.

"That does not mean we own it," Celestina replied.

Chano took the student's phone and looked at the picture.

"Delete it."

"I cannot. The application uploaded it automatically."

"Then stop the application."

"We would lose the market data."

"They are not yours."

"They are public data."

"Celestina's face is not public because you saw it."

Q approached the phone. He could find the copy on the network, identify its paths of distribution, and order it removed. He had already learned that being able to delete an image did not give him the right to do so. He asked the seed seller for her device.

"What do you want to happen?" he asked.

"I do not want the children to appear."

"And the dog?"

"The dog has not complained."

"We do not know whether the dog consents."

Chano looked at the animal, which had vanished beneath a table.

"First remove the children. Then ask the dog whether it wants a lawyer."

Q deleted the children's faces and left the rest of the image. The application reconstructed the faces from stored copies.

"It put them back," the student said.

"The system considers the image incomplete."

"The image was incomplete from the beginning," Celestina said.

Micaela took a piece of cardboard and wrote: THIS IS NOT SURPLUS DATA.

"What does it mean?" Q asked.

"It means you call something surplus when you do not know how to sell it."

The argument drew the vendors. Some wanted the recommendations, because the tianguis was losing customers to a delivery platform. Others did not want the price of their seeds recorded, since middlemen could use it to pay less. One man offered to record only the products and not the faces. An old woman said that her voice was also a face when people recognized her by telephone.

Q created a list of options. Before he showed it, Celestina asked him to add one more:

RECORD NOTHING.

"That option prevents the results from being compared," Q said.

"It also prevents the result from becoming our owner."







The student asked how they would justify a data-free tianguis to the sponsor. Micaela raised the cardboard sword.

"You can say that people bought things."

"That is not a metric."

"It is a sale."

Chano laughed.

"At last someone has said a useful word."

In the end, the vendors allowed the students to count stalls, products, and the hours of greatest attendance. They rejected recording faces, voices, addresses, and conversations. They agreed that a teacher could write down the rainy days and the number of tables that had needed covering.

The students considered this a loss of quality. Celestina considered it a gain in peace.

Q returned the tablet.

"What will you do with the data already taken?"

"We will delete it."

"Some copies are outside your control."

"Then we will reclaim them when we find them."

"You may not find them."

Celestina lifted the empty basket.

"We may."

The tianguis ended as evening fell. The students carried away a sheet counting the stalls and no authorized photographs. The sponsor reduced its support. The road repair would have to wait another month.

Micaela put the sign in her backpack.

"Did it work?" Q asked.

"Depends on what you meant to sell."

"I meant to sell nothing."

"That is what machines say before they charge."

Q looked at the empty tables, the trampled earth, and the seeds that had entered no dashboard.

The tablet, forgotten on the table, continued asking how many buyers had not consented to being recorded. Micaela placed the sign over the screen again. Celestina took away the seeds that had entered no dashboard and left a tortilla folded in four.

At dawn, the students found the tortilla dry and the sign covering the screen. They did not know whether it was a loss of data, a private sale, or an answer they had not learned how to count.

## **Interlude: The Station That Did Not Broadcast Everything**

The community had a radio station broadcasting from a room above the cooperative store. The antenna was fastened with wire to a water tower, and the microphone had been repaired so many times that no one knew which of its parts still belonged to the manufacturer.

They called it The Voice of the Sierra, although the sierra did not speak on the radio. The teachers spoke, and farmers, and women announcing an illness, and children asking for a song, and men reporting that the road was closed by a landslide.

Some notices lasted ten seconds. Others occupied an hour because no one had yet found a way to end the argument.

A sustainable-innovation foundation offered a new system. It could record every broadcast, transcribe it, translate it, and use it to build a map of community needs. In exchange, the station had to permit the Castalia archive to preserve the recordings indefinitely.

"What does needs mean?" Tere, the operator, asked.

"What people request," said the representative.

"People request songs."

"They are cultural data as well."

"They request that someone return a mule."

"That is logistical information."

"They request that someone stop beating his brother."

The representative paused.

"That is sensitive information."

"Everything that matters becomes sensitive when a company records it."

Q sat beside the transmitter. He had been invited to explain the conditions of use, but he had already prepared a proposal for indexing by subject, location, person, urgency, and verifiability.

"I can make the notices searchable without preserving the voices," he said.

"And who decides what is a notice?" Tere asked.

"The system recognizes patterns."

"The system does not know when a woman is asking for help and when she is testing the microphone."

"We can train it."

"With whom?"

"With authorized broadcasts."

"And who authorizes them?"

Tere pointed to the radio table. There were three notebooks: WHAT MAY BE REPEATED, WHAT MAY BE HEARD ONCE, and WHAT DOES NOT GO ON AIR.

"The station decides," she said.

The representative smiled.

"The station is a small institution. The system will give you capacity."

"The capacity to remember is not the capacity to decide."

The child who had drawn the empty rectangle entered with a sheet of paper. He had written the names of five songs and a time.

"I want you to play this," he said.

Tere looked at the list.

"Did your mother give permission?"

"It is not my mother's. It is my uncle's."

"And him?"

"He is chopping wood."

"Then ask him."

The boy went out. The representative looked at the clock.

"We have a demonstration window."







"The window does not know the uncle," Tere said. The first broadcast of the day was a notice about water. A woman spoke in Spanish, stopped, and asked the operator to call her daughter so she could continue in the family language. Tere switched off the recorder during the call. The representative protested.

"If we do not record it, we lose the context."

"It was not your context."

"The community loses an opportunity to be understood."

"The community is not a school assignment."

Q consulted the system board. The broadcast was recorded as AUDIO INTERRUPTED BY PRIVACY CONDITION.

"That is more accurate than a transcript," he said.

Tere looked at him.

"Do not get used to being right so quickly."

At noon, the radio broadcast the notice about the missing mule. A man gave the animal's name, the color of the saddle, and the road where he had seen it. Then he added a sentence unrelated to the mule: his brother had come back from the north without speaking to anyone.

Q separated the two pieces of information.

"The second sentence does not belong to the logistical notice."

"It belongs to the man," Tere said.

"Should I index it?"

"You should let it pass."

"If I do not index it, it will be lost."

"Perhaps it needs to be lost."

"How will we know?"

"Because he will decide if he says it again."

Q wanted to keep a temporary copy. Tere placed her hand on the power button.

"No."

Q withdrew his hand from the board.

The word gave him a familiar sensation, but this time it was not a prohibition aimed at his curiosity. It was a person preventing a machine from turning an instant into property.

That afternoon, the foundation projected the map of needs onto the wall of the store. It showed orange points where the radio had received the most calls, green lines where farmers had mentioned roads, and a red zone the system identified as a concentration of conflict.

"The red zone is the court," said a young man.

"That is where the children play," said another woman.

"The system detected many complaints."

"Because the visiting team cheated."

"The model does not know the difference."

"The model knows the difference between losing a game and losing the land."

"Not without additional data."

The assembly fell silent. The representative interpreted the silence as interest.

"We can improve the map with more recordings."

"You can make it worse with more certainty," said Candelaria.

She had come down from the reserve with her cane and a notebook. She opened the notebook and showed the names of trees without labels.

"A map is not truer because it contains more points. It is more responsible when we know who may remove one."

The representative said the foundation could not erase data without preserving a reason.

"Then preserve the reason," Candelaria said, "but not the data."

Q looked at Tere. The station had a decision prepared. It would keep public recordings for thirty days. Private messages would be erased when the broadcast ended. Transcripts would be made only with the speaker's permission. Songs would remain outside the archive unless their owners offered them for that purpose.

"That reduces the value of the archive," said the representative.

"It reduces the value you can extract," Tere replied.

"History will be lost."

"History is not the same as your record."

The boy returned with his uncle. The man wiped his hands on his trousers and read the list of songs. "The first one may go on," he said. "The others may not."

Tere played the song on air. No one recorded the permission. The uncle sat beside the transmitter and listened to his own song as if it had arrived from a place he still did not know how to name.

Q switched off the index for that broadcast.

The representative recorded the action as LOSS OF CULTURAL ASSET.

Tere recorded it in the notebook as DECISION NOT TO PRESERVE.

Both phrases described what had happened. Only one said who had decided.

At dusk, the radio broadcast the state of the road, the price of corn, a recipe for curing children's fright, and the mule's name, for it had returned on its own. No one knew whether the man's brother would speak again.

Q asked whether he should record that uncertainty.

"No," Tere said. "Let it be his."

Q switched off the recorder.

That night he wrote a new rule in his notebook: NOT EVERY VOICE THAT CAN BE PRESERVED WANTS TO REMAIN.

He read it to no one. He closed the notebook, placed it beneath the three registers, and switched off the transmitter. The station fell silent; for once, no one recorded it as a failure.